



A misunderstanding after all

A clash between Elon Musk and Tim Cook brushed off as a misunderstanding.
<https://digit.in/dec22-25>



Android users beware!

A security leak at Android has left many Android devices vulnerable to malware attacks.
<https://digit.in/dec22-26>

Is the future made of screens that will touch us back?

The professor of IIT Madras who founded India's first lab dedicated to the study of touch talks about his latest screen-tech innovation

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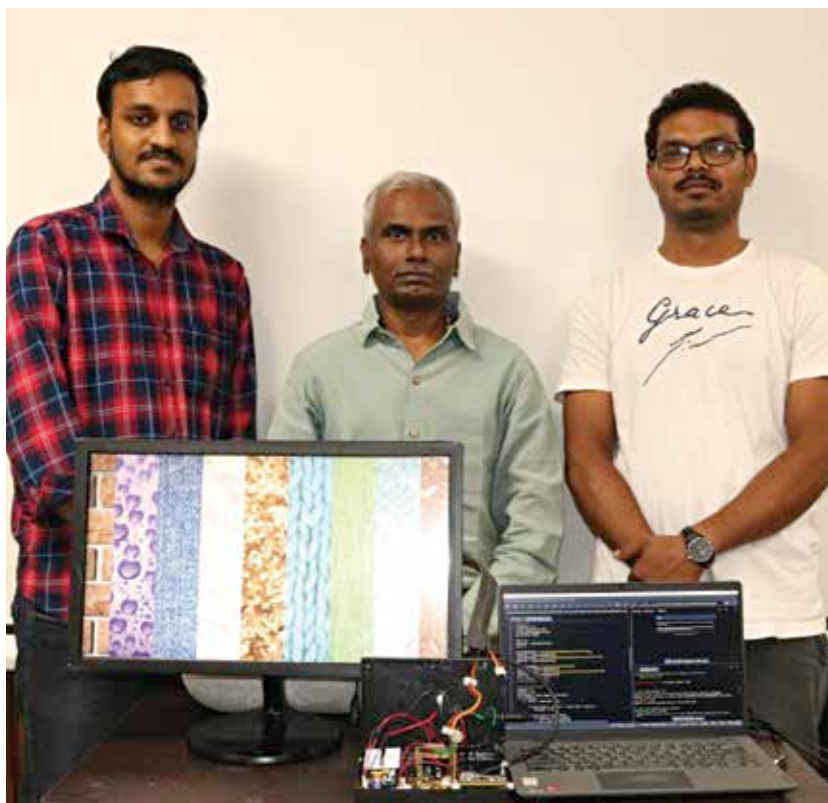
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ne objective of M Manivannan, when he established in IIT Madras India's first lab dedicated to the

study of touch, was to fully appreciate what he believed to be the most important sense of all the fundamental senses. After sixteen years, his confident and forceful belief is still standing erect on the grounds of a solid argument, which he often repeats – vision and taste, smell and hearing are just restricted to the head, the touch is in the entire body.

“Since I am running a laboratory called Touch Labs, I say it is not just a claim, but I have a solid proof,” he continues on a subject that clearly fires him up. “Your vision will not work if touch is not working. Your hearing will not work if touch is not working. Your taste will not work. Even your smell will not.”

It is perhaps why he finds it so odd that the screens on which we are perpetually running our thumbs and fingers are not touching us back. Touch, which he believes is so fundamental to humans and their experience of the world, is near absent from our online



Professor M Manivannan

lives in today's time. Mindlessly scrolling to the bottom of the internet, the most we feel is the touch of cold glass or the body of our phones.

Touchscreens in the market, for better or worse, are yet to go touchy-feely. Right now, they just sense the position of our fingers and move the cursor there. But Manivannan feels that such tactile deprivation on digital devices is unlike the real world and isn't intuitive. “When you are interacting with mobile phones, when you are using computers, when you're in virtual reality, you want to feel as if you are in the real world. You want the touch feedback”, he remarks.

For some reason, techies all around the world are collectively convinced

that people want the virtual world to ape the real one. In Manivannan's vision, it will involve him greeting people over Zoom with a high-five, with the surface of the laptop supplanting the touch of human palm. Or shopping on e-commerce platforms after feeling the texture of the shirt and shoes on the laptop. Or the addictive smartphones supplying all sorts of synthetic touches to the fingers that can't go an hour without tapping all over their surface.

THE TOUCHY-FEELY TOUCHSCREEN

A professor of biomedical engineering, M Manivannan forayed into haptics during his stint as a